> The mental hospital at Shahdara [a locality in east Delhi] had opened a branch inside Tihar to cater to the needs of the inmates. Most of the patients were women. In the evenings some unfortunate women inmates from this branch hospital were forced to come and stand at the outer gates of the prison and customers brought in from the roadside who would pay the jail staff for the privilege of fondling these women through the bars of the main gate. Just after the Emergency Sanjay Gandhi was lodged in this jail and his wife Maneka would often come to visit him here. It was she who discovered this obscenity and published it in *Surya*, a magazine she then ran.

Such conditions obviously created a warped mindset. Excessive urge for any form of stimulation was felt by a large number of inmates. This urge probably could be fulfilled only by drugs or bizarre sexual behaviour. Tolerance was at an all-time low and this abnormal situation could have only bred feelings of hatred and revenge towards individual or specific sections of society, and it could have also led to despair. Thinking became tunnelled and inflexible, leading to the hardening of hearts and corruption of minds. The prisoners certainly lost all ability to process their own emotions, resulting in constant outbreaks of fights, hysteria and depression.

The Tihar situation raised certain very disturbing questions:

- Should a prison serve as penitentiary or should it be a means of societal revenge?
- Should society sit in judgement over an individual while ignoring its own collective guilt?
- Should our complacency, deriving from a conditioned adherence to prevailing systems, override our human compulsions of interaction and understanding?
- Should we continue to accept the myth that only those people who are guilty of criminal offences should serve periods of imprisonment?
- Should we believe that an aberration of judgement is indicative of a hardened heart and a criminal mind?
- Should our quest for legality be exclusive of our sensitivities towards another's rights as a human being?

Answers to such questions cannot be derived merely academically. The human condition that gives rise to such questions has to be lived and experienced. This chapter, entitled 'Freedom from Fear', is an attempt to provide such an experience to the reader.

As one recaptures the dramatic moments of the post-May 1993 events, one is inexorably drawn towards the conclusion that despite the fact that changes came about almost spontaneously and instinctively, there was a certain discernible pattern to them.

The conditions prevailing in the past in Tihar Jail had promoted a very unhealthy mentality, which was steadily criminalizing the minds of its unfortunate inmates. There was an unhealthy absence of any constructive or creative activity. The environment was overcrowded and unhygienic. Medical aid was almost nonexistent. If at all there was any responsibility given, it went without any sense of accountability. Above all, and probably what was the root cause of such an appalling situation, was that there appeared to be no one with any sensitivity to the abounding misery.